Wenda Zhang

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EDUCATION

University of Chicago, Chicago, IL *08/2026 – 06/2027 (expected)*
M.A. in Economics; Chair Scholar Award ($10,000)

University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign, Urbana, IL *01/2024 – 05/2026*
B.S. in Econometrics and Quantitative Economics, with Distinction; GPA 3.64/4.00; Dean's List (2024)
Undergraduate thesis advisor: Prof. Riley League

Xi'an Jiaotong-Liverpool University, Suzhou, China *08/2022 – 01/2024*
Economics and Finance; First-Class standing (top 10% of department); transferred to UIUC

RESEARCH

Performance Measures and Local Government Behavior: Evidence from China's Wastewater Treatment Targets
with Yuhang Pan (Peking University) and Haotian Yu (Georgia Institute of Technology). Working paper. *2026 – present*

- Study how Chinese cities responded to the treatment-rate targets of the 11th Five-Year Plan (2006–2010), using a two-sided continuous-treatment DiD on each city's baseline distance from its target, event studies, and within-city stacked comparisons of assessed and unassessed infrastructure.
- Find that cities further below target raised treated volume, capacity, and plant numbers but not sewer networks or other unassessed infrastructure.
- Built the analysis panel of 227 prefecture-level cities (2002–2013) in Stata from raw *China Urban Construction* and *City Statistical Yearbook* files, with header checks, consistency flags, and documented sample rules; extended the pre-period to 1999 from digitized yearbook tables.
- Showed that cities already above their targets did not change treated volume, which makes the bend at the target the paper's main identifying feature, and that the margin of response depended on existing capacity: cities with idle capacity raised plant utilization, while capacity-constrained cities built new plants.
- Led the environmental analysis: hand-entered yearbook readings for 360 river monitoring sections, matched weekly national automatic-station data to cities with weather controls, and added key-city domestic discharge records; the sources agree that river quality and domestic discharge did not improve detectably.
- Audited the full draft by tracing each reported estimate back to code output and re-estimating specifications whose numbers did not match.

When Treatment Intensity Is Built from the Baseline Outcome: Mechanical Convergence in Distance-to-Target Designs
with Yuhang Pan and Haotian Yu. Working paper. *2026 – present*

- Identified, while estimating the wastewater design, that a dose built from the gap between a target and the baseline outcome produces a dose response through regression to the mean alone; proposed developing the problem as a separate paper.
- Derive the mechanical dose response; show that coding units past the target as zero inflates it, and that a two-sided spline isolates the kink at the target, which can itself be mechanical.
- Conducted the reanalysis of six published studies in Stata: reproduced the core estimates from the authors' replication files or public data, rebuilt each dose on both sides of the target, and applied the diagnostics.

Shadow-Schooling Shutdown: The Impact of China's Double Reduction Policy on Household Education Expenditure and Consumption Behavior
Undergraduate thesis, UIUC. Advisor: Prof. Riley League. *03/2025 – 12/2025*

- Built child- and household-level two-wave panels from the 2020 and 2022 China Family Panel Studies by merging the child, family-economy, and family-roster modules and aggregating child records to households.
- Estimated a DiD comparing households whose children were all in compulsory schooling with households whose children were all in kindergarten or high school.
- Found that off-campus tutoring spending fell by about 1,000 yuan per child and household education spending by 1,600–2,000 yuan, with no detectable change in total consumption, its composition, or the average propensity to consume.

RESEARCH ASSISTANT EXPERIENCE

Historical U.S. Agricultural Credit and Production | Prof. Jared Hutchins, UIUC *09/2024 – 05/2025*

- Digitized archival agricultural and financial records with OCR, verified extracted values by hand, and structured them into a database linking credit conditions to agricultural production (Stata, Excel).
- Maintained the project datasets and coordinated data tasks within the research team.

Breakthrough Innovation in Firms | Prof. Xiao Wang, XJTLU *08/2023 – 12/2023*

- Organized firm data, constructed variables, ran preliminary regressions, and reviewed the literature for the project's framework.

AI Adoption in Auditing: Textual Evidence | Prof. Linhan Zhang, XJTLU *08/2023 – 12/2023*

- Collected online documents through web scraping and built a structured text corpus on AI-enabled audit quality and transparency.

PROJECT

The Scholars Daily, Founder & Editor, *2026–present*

A bilingual (Chinese/English) morning digest that helps researchers keep up with new work in their field during breakfast or the commute. Each short edition offers narrative briefings on a few recent papers, covering the question, identification, key results, and limitations. Beta launched in October 2026. https://daily.scholarsdaily.com

SKILLS

Programming: Stata (advanced: panel construction and cleaning, reghdfe, event studies), R, Python (web scraping, text processing), MATLAB, LaTeX, Excel

Data: China Family Panel Studies; Chinese urban construction, city, and environment yearbooks; firm-level environmental survey; national water-quality monitoring; archival records (OCR)

Tests: GRE Verbal 160, Quantitative 170, Analytical Writing 4.0 (10/2025)

SELECTED COURSEWORK

Graduate (UChicago): Microeconomics, Macroeconomics, Econometrics (in progress)

Econometrics and Statistics: Intermediate Econometrics, Advanced Economic Statistics, Financial Econometrics, Economic Forecasting, International Macroeconomics Forecast

Mathematics: Probability Theory, Linear Algebra, Differential Equations, Advanced Calculus

Field Courses: Public Economics, Behavioral Economics, International Trade, Monetary Economics

LEADERSHIP

Law Society, XJTLU — President and Head of Academic Affairs *03/2023 – 12/2023*

- Contributed to building a legal and policy text database via web scraping and OCR
- organized seminars on current affairs and law and led society to host academic lectures.

REFERENCES

Prof. Riley League, Department of Economics, University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign — league@illinois.edu
Prof. Yuhang Pan, Department of Economics, Peking University — yhpan@pku.edu.cn
Prof. Jared Hutchins, Department of Consumer and Agriculture Economics, UIUC — jhtchns2@illinois.edu